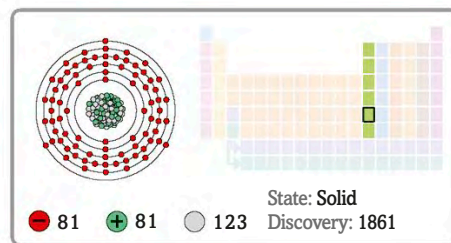


81

Tl

Thallium



Forms

The grey crust on this aluminium mineral contains small amounts of thallium.

This mineral contains iron, sulfur, and tiny amounts of thallium.

Thallium alum

Pyrite

Laboratory sample of pure thallium in an airless vial

This soft and silvery metal is kept in a sealed glass tube as it is highly toxic and reacts easily with air.

Thallium was named after the Greek word *thallos*, which means “green shoot”: it was first identified from the colours in its flame, which includes a bright green light. Thallium was discovered in 1861 by William Crookes and Claude-Auguste Lamy. Although

both chemists worked separately, they found the element in the same way – as a residue while making strong acids using the mineral **pyrite**. Thallium was later found to exist in larger amounts in other minerals, including **thallium alum**. **Pure thallium** is toxic and has to be handled